My Mother Named me Hamlette

by Anthony Doyle



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[A SCHOOL HALLWAY]

MOM. Good morrow, Hamlette! Tis your first day of a new school year.

HAMLETTE. This is an absolute nightmare.

MOM. Goodly daughter Hamlette, why dost thou hide thy face in these hallowed halls of education?

HAMLETTE. In case you had not noticed, it is the first day of school and I am on parade with my Shakespearean scholar mother and my sickeningly smart and adorable little sister.

DESDEMONA. Hi.

HAMLETTE. Any hope I had of a normal, non-outcast year is gone.

MOM. Take heart, my dear Hamlette. For while thy face doth blush for thy mother, 'tis but a day that I intrude.

HAMLETTE. You know, that's true. You will leave soon and if it were that simple, I think I could get over it. But it isn't!

MOM. Hamlette! What have I told thee about using contractions?

DESDEMONA. "That it is commoner's speech, mother. It is a vernacular unfit for the ears of a superior child such as I. That it shall be absorbed and imitated, thereby hindering the development of my genius."

HAMLETTE. That's exactly what I'm talking about!

MOM. Hamlette!

HAMLETTE. That *is* exactly what I *am* talking about.

MOM. Much better. Now then, Hamlette, thy sister, Desdemona, needs additional social development before she casts off this mediocre coil and matriculates to university.

HAMLETTE. Right. You have to enroll my 7-year-old freaky smart sister in all my classes because she needs to make friends. Except that she (points)—

DESDEMONA. (scribbling in a notebook and gawking at other kids) Fascinating! It is the adolescent sociological phenomenon at work.

HAMLETTE. —Is like friend repellent…for me!

MOM. Thou art dramatic, Hamlette.

HAMLETTE. And whose fault is that. you named me Hamlette!

DESDEMONA. Hark! The bell hath rung! And we have reached my first class! Huzzah!

MOM. Huzzah!

HAMLETTE. And so begins the great tragedy of my life.

Margaret Mead once said, "Sister is the most competitive relationship in the family, but once the sisters are grown, it becomes the strongest relationship." While Mead's words may eventually prove true for Hamlette and her baby sister Desdemona, when it comes to the growing up part…aye there's the rub. As they navigate the drama of middle school, friendships and Shakespeare, they each learn the blessing and burden of sisterhood and both are reminded this above all, to thine own self be true. My Mother Named me Hamlette by Anthony Doyle

[A SCHOOL HALLWAY, MOM HAS JUST LEFT]

DESDEMONA. Farewell, Mother. Parting is such sweet sorrow.

HAMLETTE. Whatever. Look, Dez, don't get me wrong. I love you and we actually get along

DESDEMONA. Mostly because we do not have much in common.

HAMLETTE. Exactly. I mean, really—what am I going to do, steal your math textbooks?

DESDEMONA. Haha, no. You wouldn't understand them.

HAMLETTE. The point is I want you to get along at school. For your sake and mine. So here are the ground rules—

DESDEMONA. Oh, Mother and I already discussed the skills I will need.

[FLASHBACK TO THE PREVIOUS NIGHT]

MOM. Now, Desdemona, pray thee let us try it again. "Good morrow, new student. That is a nice book bag you have there."

DESDEMONA. Thank you

MOM. "Would you like to buy some drugs? They will make you smarter."

DESDEMONA. No thank you. Drugs are incongruous with my health and life goals. Perhaps we could partake in some dry roasted almonds, instead?

MOM. Huzzah!

[FLASHFORWARD TO PRESENT]

HAMLETTE. Ugh.

DESDEMONA Is that incorrect? My research shows a high favorability for adolescents and dry roasted almonds—

HAMLETTE. Dez, here is a simple rule of thumb. Just…don't be you. Can you do that?

DESDEMONA. Although I cannot fully comprehend the necessity of compromising myself for the sake of assimilating to the group, I trust your experience in the matter.

[THEY ENTER THE CLASSROOM]

TEACHER. Brittannie Gwen?

BRITTANI. Here!

TEACHER. Stefani Gwen?

STEFANI. Double here.

HAMLETTE. Ugh, the Gwens? I can't even believe they made it to eighth grade.

STEFANI. I know, right? I mean, hey!

BRITANI. A little late, aren't we, Spamlet?

TEACHER. Late on the first day, Hamlette? Not an auspicious start to the year

DESDEMONA. I agree sir, better three hours too soon than a minute too late.

TEACHER. Ah, quoting Shakespeare! Very good young lady.

DESDEMONA It is a reflex.

HAMLETTE. Sorry Mr. S. We won't let it happen again.

TEACHER. And who is your friend?

DESDEMONA. Desdemona Richards. Newly matriculated.
HAMLETTE. Don't curtsied.
TEACHER. Desdemona! Do you go by any other names?
DESDEMONA. A rose by any other name would—
HAMLETTE. Dez! She's goes by Dez.
BRITTANI. Is it "bring your dorky sibling to school day?"
HAMLETTE. Yeah, that's why your sister brought you.
STEFANI. Nah-uh. Mom made me.
TEACHER. Now, now kids, either you quit all that or I'm sending you to the office. What's it to be?
DESDEMONA. (gasps) To Be or—
HAMLETTE. (covers her mouth) She has tourettes. We'll just sit down now.
TEACHER. Well, I'm glad you're all sitting because I think you'll all be particularly interested in our inter-disciplinary project this term. Especially you and your sister, Hamlette.
HAMLETTE. Uh-oh.
TEACHER. We'll be doing an eight-week segment on A Midsummer Night's Dream. Written by…
DESDEMONA. Oooooh!
HAMLETTE. No.
TEACHER. William Shakespeare!
DESDEMONA. Huzzah!

[HAMLETTE AND DESDEMONA'S HOUSE, LATER THAT DAY]

HAMLETTE. That was a complete disaster!
MOM. (sword fighting for fitness) Anon! My scholars are returned! HAMLETTE, why dost thou face hang low and foul?
HAMLETTE. Why not ask my brilliant little sister?
DESDEMONA. I know not of what you speak, dear sister.
HAMLETTE. Oh, you "know not?" How about the scene you pulled in science?
SCIENCE TEACHER. The skull is a very important bone in your body…
DESDEMONA. Alas, poor Yorick…Hamlette, I knew him…
HAMLETTE. Or home-ec?
DESDEMONA. What light through yonder window bakes? It is the yeast! And Juliet has the buns!
JULIET. (as she eats the buns) Lay off me, I'm starving!
HAMLETTE. And I don't even want to mention what happened during dodgeball
DESDEMONA. What, art thou drawn among these heartless hinds? Turn thee, Benvolio, look upon thy death.
MOM. Methinks these seem perfectly reasonable responses.
HAMLETTE. Says the woman doing ye olde aerobics Ugh. It was bad enough when I just had to deal with you two at home. Why can't you just act normal?
DESDEMONA. Because I am not what one would consider normal due to my age and intellect. It would be contradictory for me to act in the way of a standard student.
HAMLETTE. Ugh!

DESDEMONA. Oh, Mother! Before I should forget, I have news! Among my adventures today, I made two friends.

MOM. How fortuitous!

HAMLETTE. Wait, what? WHO?

DESDEMONA. Brittannie and Stefani.

HAMLETTE. The Gwens? Hahahahaha. No, Dez. They aren't your friends.

DESDEMONA. Yes, yes they are. I was paired with them in a group assignment. We got along like crusty bread and mead!

HAMLETTE. Dez –

[DOORBELL RINGS]

STEFANI. Yoo-hoo

BRITTANI. We are outside the front door.

HAMLETTE. No way. (opens door) Seriously?

BRITTANI. Seriously.

HAMLETTE. Dezzie, you can't be friends with them.

STEFANI. And why not, Spamlet?

HAMLETTE. Because you are not friends with people like us. You don't even talk to people like us. Not unless you count your repeated renditions of "Spamlet's Mommy wears a cape like Batman"

BRITTANI. Oh my god, I love that song.

DESDEMONA. I do not understand why you are so upset with me, Hamlette. I am making friends!

STEFANI. Bestie friendsies. Like Hermia and Helena in the Middle Summer's Ice Cream.

BRITTANI. Mmmm, Ice Cream.

DESDEMONA. No, that is incorrect.

STEFANI. Oh right, cuz they aren't besties in the play. Cuz when Dmitri and Lysol-

DESDEMONA. Demetrius and Lysander.

STEFANI. Whatever. When they both start liking Helena, Hermia gets mad at her. And they get in this huge fight. It's not Helena's fault that they like her. Right?

HAMLETTE. Whoa. That question sounds A LOT like the homework assignment on character relationships in the play.

DESDEMONA. Hermia thinks that they are playing a mean joke on her.

HAMLETTE. Gasp! You're using Dezzie to get ahead in English!

STEFANI. Pfft. Fftt. Shhhht. Pfft.

BRITT. God Bless You.

STEFANI. Dezzie, do you think we could have some privacy?

DESDEMONA. Oh, of course. You may leave us now, Hamlette.

HAMLETTE. Dezzie! They aren't your friends. They probably just want you to give them the answers for their stupid presentation!

DESDEMONA. How would you know? You don't like them. It is obvious that you are envious of their social stature and, thus, my interaction with them.

HAMLETTE. That's not it. I'm trying to help you.

DESDEMONA. By telling me not to be me? By telling me I cannot speak or participate or make friends? I do not need your help anymore. Hamlet, I am doing just fine on my own.

HAMLETTE. And just like that, my genius little sister became an idiot.

DESDEMONA. You would know.

HAMLETTE. Wherefore was I to this keen mockery born? When at your hands did I deserve this scorn?

DESDEMONA. Get thee to a nunnery, Spamlette.

HAMLETTE. You curly-haired wretch!

DESDEMONA. Fair thee well!

BRITT. What just happened…?

STEFANI. I think it's like Hippolyta. Right, Dezzie? Cuz she's such a good representation of Shakespeare's feelings of the female as a slave?

DESDEMONA. Hmmm…?

[THE CLASSROOM, A WEEK LATER]

TEACHER. For our first presentation, Stefani and Brittani Gwen will introduce the life of the Bard.

HAMLETTE. I bet they didn't come up with a single word of this.

STEFANI. William Shakespeare was born in 1564, in Strapping-Up-An-oven, New England.

HAMLETTE. Pfft.

BRITTANI. Bless you.

STEFANI. As a child, he enjoyed horseback riding and playing the accordion.

HAMLETTE. Ffft – wait, what?

BRITTANI. Yeah, and his famous friends included Benjamin Franklin, Leonardo DaVinci, and Mozart. And most people think he was just a writer, but he also discovered Oregon and named Williamette valley after himself.

STEFANI. An excellent point, Britt. I also believe our lives would be totally unliveable if the Bard had not invented Bardbie dolls…

TEACHER. Ladies! That is quite enough.

STEFANI. What?

TEACHER. You're just making things up. And that's an insult to the bard and to my class. You should be ashamed.

STEFANI. No wait, we…but…Dezzie…

DESDEMONA. Though she be but little, she is fierce.

HAMLETTE. Huzzah! And my Mommy wears a cape…because she's better than batman!

TEACHER. Stefani and Brittani. Come with me please.

HAMLETTE. Dezzie! That was amazing. They hadn't even double-checked to make sure that your information was accurate!

DESDEMONA. Mmmhmmm, I can be wrong. Sometimes.

HAMLETTE. We all can be wrong sometimes.

DESDEMONA. I think I've known they were using me for a while, but I wanted you to be wrong. Even though that's not logical. Are you mad at me?

HAMLETTE. No, Dez, I'm not mad at you. I'm proud of you. Just the way you are. But I am sorry. I know you wanted them to be your friends.

DESDEMONA. Who needs them? I've got you.

HAMLETTE. Having a brainiac little sister is tough enough, but when she's not only smart, but you kind of like her, that makes it even worse.

DESDEMONA. Huzzah!

HAMLETTE. …huzzah.